

Are the Red Sox Cooking?

Updated to include Harold Rivas

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Introduction

The Boston Red Sox have had an eventful season. After a very miserable start, they experienced an incredible turnaround, including a miraculous July.

Span	W-L	RS/G	RA/G	Odds to Make Playoffs
Before 6/25	32-46	3.94	4.03	10.6%
Since	28-5	5.06	3.03	89.6%

Table 1: What a turnaround!

Their July was so torrid, it was actually their best calendar month in franchise history. Their offense finally came around, and while the Red Sox pitching was already elite, it has reached another level in this 33-game span.

Span	<i>wRC+</i>		<i>ISO</i>		<i>HR%</i>		<i>xWOB</i>		<i>fWAR</i>	
	Stat	Rank	Stat	Rank	Stat	Rank	Stat	Rank	Stat	Rank
Before 6/25	92	24th	.141	27th	2.3%	29th	.305	29th	8.3	20th
Since	104	11th	.178	9th	3.5%	9th	.316	10th	4.7	11th

Table 2: Batting Increase

Span	<i>ERA</i>		<i>FIP</i>		<i>WHIP</i>		<i>SIERA</i>		<i>fWAR</i>	
	Stat	Rank	Stat	Rank	Stat	Rank	Stat	Rank	Stat	Rank
Before 6/25	3.82	7th	3.92	8th	1.27	12th	3.89	7th	8.9	8th
Since	2.89	1st	3.25	1st	1.13	4th	3.59	4th	6.4	1st

Table 3: Pitching Increase

With this turnaround, the Red Sox changed course on their deadline plans. Such a surge turned them from expected sellers into buyers. And they went on quite the spending spree.

- **July 25 - Trade with Nationals**
 - Red Sox receive: 1B/3B Curtis Mead
 - Nationals receive: LHP Connelly Early

- **August 1 - Trade with Tigers**
 - Red Sox receive: OF Jahmai Jones
 - Tigers receive: LHP Jojo Ingrassia
- **August 3 - Trade with Orioles**
 - Red Sox receive: C Adley Rutschman and C Jake Rogers
 - Orioles receive: RHP Anthony Eyanson, RHP Kyson Witherspoon, OF Enddy Azocar, OF Harold Rivas, and C Carlos Narváez
- **August 3 - Trade with Giants**
 - Red Sox receive: LHP Erik Miller
 - Giants receive: SS/2B Marcelo Mayer
- **August 3 - Trade with Braves**
 - Red Sox receive: OF Eli White
 - Braves receive: RHP Tyler Uberstine

Five of the eight players dealt by Boston are prospects. Early and Mayer are both well under a year of service time, and Narváez is the most “established” piece having reached one year of service time. To get a clearer picture of the pieces dealt by Boston, here’s a snapshot of the eight players.

Pos	Player	Age (as of 8/3/26)	Organization Rank	Top 100
LHP	Jojo Ingrassia	24.03	45	
RHP	Anthony Eyanson	21.82	3	27
RHP	Kyson Witherspoon	21.97	10	
OF	Enddy Azocar	19.44	4	82
OF	Harold Rivas	18.23	9	
RHP	Tyler Uberstine	27.17	21	

Table 4: FanGraphs Prospect Rankings

Pos	Player	Age	Org. Rank	Top 100	MLB Stats
LHP	Connelly Early	24.33	4	40	111 IP, 95 <i>FIP</i> –, 1.1 <i>fWAR</i>
C	Carlos Narváez	27.69	10		658 PA, 82 <i>wRC</i> +, 2.7 <i>fWAR</i>
SS/2B	Marcelo Mayer	23.64	3	14	364 PA, 69 <i>wRC</i> +, 0.3 <i>fWAR</i>

Table 5: FanGraphs Graduate Prospect Rankings

The Red Sox made a huge commitment to the present. They traded a pair of top-100 prospects and two former top-50 prospects. Their farm system obviously suffered tremendously per the rankings. The Red Sox farm was ranked 12th overall entering the deadline; now they sit at 28th, third-to-last [3]. It’s a very scary spot to be in, going from investing in the future to a push for the present, especially with the departing prospect capital. It’s very easy and understandable to see the headlines and immediately think the Red Sox gave up too many valuable pieces. Is that really the case?

The Im-mead-iate Future

The Early-for-Mead trade shocking when it went down. It was difficult to understand; Early looked like a cemented rotation member after his dazzling debut last season. He struggled in June (4.40 *ERA*, 1.43 *WHIP*), but still.

Curtis Mead is a former top-100 prospect himself, although his career has slumped out of the gate. People were quick to note that he had been on three teams in four seasons, but we are not seeing the same Curtis Mead in 2026 that we saw before.

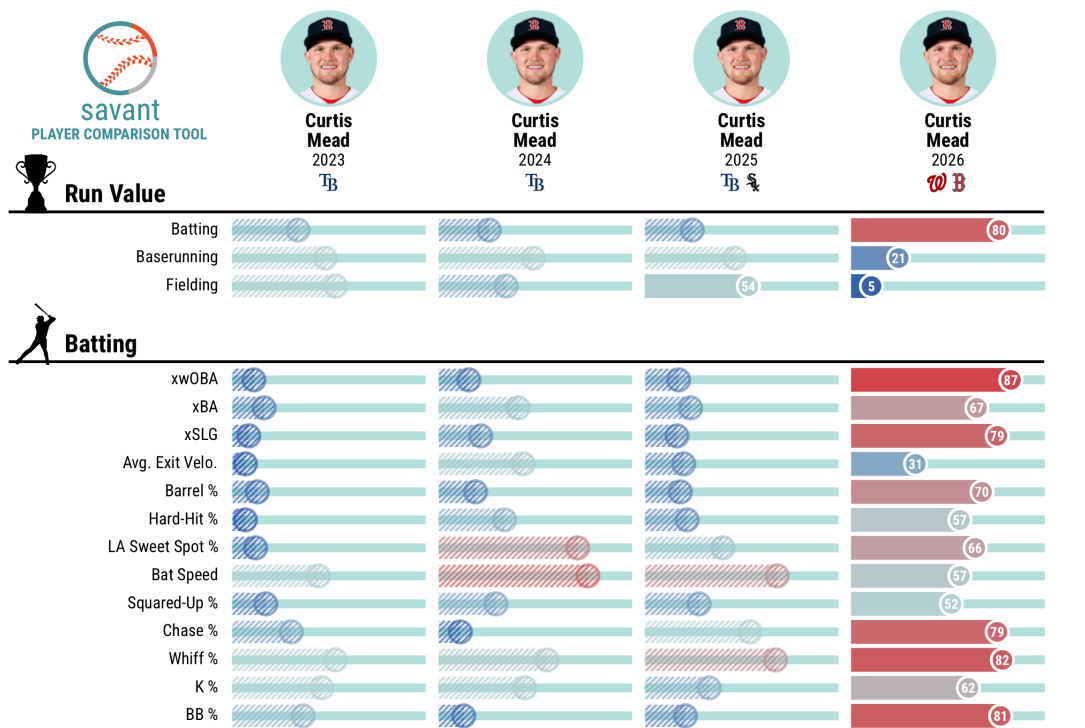


Figure 1: Curtis Mead's Evolution

Span	G	PA	wRC+	ISO	HR	BB/K	fWAR
2023-25	152	488	77	.079	5	0.25	0.1
2026	88	329	134	.246	17	0.62	1.6

Table 6: New Year, New Mead

Mead had a career revival in Washington. He went from a weak bat that couldn't make contact to an elite power bat. Mead's ISO ranks 19th in the MLB this year (min. 300 PA), directly ahead of both Bryce Harper and Max Muncy. Not bad. He's made some serious adjustments that have turned him into a much more productive offensive player.

Span	Pull%	Hard Hit%	Barrel%	xSLG	xWOB	BABIP
2023-25	36.0%	28.8%	4.2%	.346	.285	.308
2026	48.6%	37.4%	10.8%	.457	.358	.268

Table 7: Mead's Batted Ball Stats

These peripheral numbers suggest that Mead’s newfound power might be legit. His biggest adjustment is he’s pulling the ball far more often, nearly half of the time. His hard-hit rate grew by nearly ten percent, and his barrel rate more than doubled. As for Mead’s swing decisions, they have also improved. Mead has become a more selective batter in the box.

Span	Chase%	Swing%	Contact%	Whiff%
2023-25	30.9%	49.3%	80.5%	9.6%
2026	25.0%	40.5%	83.6%	6.6%

Table 8: Curtis Mead’s Swing Decisions

What’s interesting about Mead’s case is that his swing stats had gradually improved year-to-year and 2026 has seen him finally break out. This season has been the reward for years of hard work. I’m convinced that Mead’s bat has turned a corner. What I am not convinced of is Mead being a true everyday third baseman, where he’s played 48 out of 88 games this year.

Season	1B				2B				3B			
	Inn.	DRS	OAA	FRV	Inn.	DRS	OAA	FRV	Inn.	DRS	OAA	FRV
2023	0				31	0	1	1	149	2	0	0
2024	4	0	0	0	159	-3	-3	-2	105.1	-1	-1	0
2025	206.1	-1	-2	-1	108.2	2	2	1	229	-1	0	0
2026	201	-1	-6	-4	26	1	0	0	380.2	-2	-4	-3

Table 9: Mead’s defensive stats

This is the less encouraging part of including Mead in long-term plans. Two-way players are very hard to come by, but Mead doesn’t appear to have a true position. His best defensive stretch was his work at second base in 2025. Currently, Masataka Yoshida is the everyday DH for the Red Sox, and he’s under contract until the end of next season. Given the departure of Marcelo Mayer and the presence of Caleb Durbin and Willson Contreras, Mead is most likely to occupy second base, likely demoting Nick Sogard.

Having acquired Connelly Early, the Nationals were declared the winners of this trade by public sentiment due to his early returns, youth, and the value of a good starting pitcher. However, Mead has played in less than 250 games and has less than 1000 plate appearances. He’s very young himself. Early has only pitched 111 innings in the MLB. After a fantastic cup of coffee to close 2025, he fell back down to Earth in 2026.

Season	G	IP	ERA	WHIP	FIP	SIERA
2025	4	19.1	2.33	1.09	0.91	2.34
2026	17	91.2	3.44	1.25	4.60	4.01

Table 10: Early’s first two seasons

Early’s *FIP* definitely looks a little ugly. However, I believe there is some hope for Early in this dropping. Key word being “some.”

Season	HR/FB%	Hard Hit%	Barrel%	Avg. EV (mph)
2025	0.0%	35.6%	4.4%	87.9
2026	15.2%	33.9%	10.6%	90.6

Table 11: Early's Allowed Contact

His home run rate exploded after not allowing any in 2025. His career minor league *HR/FB%* is about 10.2%, and given the lack of increase in Early's hard hit rate, there is an argument to be made that he's getting unlucky. However, his barrel rate more than doubled and his average allowed exit velocity grew as well. In terms of allowed contact, Early is in pretty poor company:

Stat	Value	Percentile
Avg. EV	90.6	13
Barrel%	10.6%	8
Soft Hit%	11.8%	13

Table 12: Early's Contact Percentiles

These stats don't look very good, but despite these stats, there are certainly aspects to like about Early's game:

Stat	Value	Percentile
<i>K/BB</i>	2.74	50
<i>LOB%</i>	86.4%	99
<i>SIERA</i>	4.01	59

Table 13: Early's Contact Percentiles

Early has gotten into messes but he has shown the ability to battle through and limit damage. However, Early's standing among starters (with 90+ innings) reads more like an average starting pitcher. He looked like an absolute stud in 2025, so what happened in 2026 when he played more games? In addition to the contact rates, he also allowed more walks:

Year	BB%	BB/9	K%	K/9	Location+
2025	5.1%	1.86	36.7%	13.50	109
2026	8.7%	3.34	23.8%	9.13	97

Table 14: Early's walk and strikeout rates

It should be noted that Early maintained a 30% strikeout rate while in the minors; the Nationals must hope that his true K-rate is closer to that than what we have seen in 2026. However, his walk rate in the minors was close to nine percent, so Early's 2025 season was more of a fluke and 2026 is what we can likely expect in terms of command. On the bright side, in terms of stuff, Early has a very strong pitch mix.

Overall	Fastball		Sinker		Slider		Cutter		Changeup	
Stuff+	Pct	Stuff+	Pct	Stuff+	Pct	Stuff+	Pct	Stuff+	Pct	Stuff+
103	35.1%	106	19.9%	96	15.9%	102	10.9%	105	18.3%	103

Table 15: Early's stuff

All of these stats start to make it more understandable as to why the Red Sox would pull the trigger on this trade. We already covered how their pitching ranked within the top ten before this stretch of brilliance; their offense needed to finally contribute. Adding Mead, who is still yet to reach arbitration, seems to be a shrewd pickup. Early might be a case of being publicly overvalued; he had a very strong start in 2025, and his 2026 season has not lived up to that hype. The stats don't read like an elite pitcher.

There is one last factor that makes this trade very murky in terms of evaluation: Early has not pitched since the end of June. He has been on the IL with an elbow injury. Depending on its severity, it raises a couple of questions, at least: Has Early been struggling with elbow discomfort this season? Did the Nationals trade for damaged goods? Hopefully not. As far as the Nationals are concerned, they are selling high on a reclamation project in hopes of gaining a reliable ace in a pitching staff begging for some talent and consistency.

Jojo-for-Jahmai

This is a very low stakes trade, but it feels redundant and comes with some hopeful questions. Prior to last season, Jahmai Jones played four years with four different teams, totaling 137 plate appearances. Last year, he broke out with the Tigers as a strong platoon bat. He eclipsed his career total with 150 plate appearances in 2025, 122 of them coming against lefties.

Stat	Value	Percentile
<i>wRC+</i>	167	96
<i>SLG%</i>	.577	95
<i>ISO</i>	.288	96
<i>BB%</i>	12.3%	85

Table 16: 2025 Jahmai Jones's ranks against lefties (min. 120 PA)

In theory, Jones has a role within a team. His slugging against lefties would make him valuable in a pinch hit situation, especially for a playoff team. The issue is that Jones has not followed up that same level in 2026.

Split	PA	Triple Slash	<i>wRC+</i>	<i>BB%</i>
vs LHP	88	.154/.250/.256	45	11.4%
vs RHP	17	.059/.059/.059	-82	0.0%

Table 17: Jahmai Jones's 2026 Splits with Detroit

It should be noted that Jones's *xwOBA* (.290) was significantly higher than his actual *wOBA* (.206). It's still not good, but much better than .206. There is a caveat about this trade: Jones was actually shipped to Boston on July 14; the trade was finalized on August 1st when the PTBNL was confirmed. Jones has had fifteen plate appearances as a member of the Red Sox so far, with thirteen of them coming against lefties.

PA	Triple Slash	<i>wRC+</i>	<i>BB%</i>
13	.455/.538/1.182	354	15.4%

Table 18: Jones's early returns vs LHP with Boston

Boston ranks third in $wRC+$ (113) against lefties in 2026. They have four players with a $wRC+ \geq 130$: Contreras (168), Abreu (165), Monasterio (159), Rafaela (130). Two of those three players are outfielders. The Red Sox are missing Roman Anthony and Jarren Duran has been dreadful in the batter's box. They're a pair of left-handed batters, which helps explain why Boston ranks 27th in $wRC+$ (91) against righties. The recently acquired Mead has posted 146 $wRC+$ against lefties in 2026.

Again, The Red Sox already have Masataka Yoshida, who has a very comparable skill set to Jahmai Jones. They are a pair of bats with no defensive value; Yoshida has a 103 $wRC+$ this season, and funny enough, he has performed well against lefties in a limited sample this season (134 $wRC+$ in 28 PA). I suppose the Red Sox acquired Jones as a situational platoon bat, but it's a strange fit for what they appear to need.

Ingrassia is a former 14th-round pick from 2023. He's a relatively uninspiring 24-year-old prospect who's still pitching in High-A (44 IP, 3.27 ERA , 3.46 FIP). He has good stuff, but he struggles with walks (12.1 $K/9$, 4.5 $BB/9$ in 2026). However, he hasn't had a bad season in the minors yet, which adds to his appeal to explain why the Tigers would make this trade. His $xFIP$ in 2026 was a career low (3.86) and he will need to control his walk rate (12.3 $BB\%$) to continue his ascent through the minors.

Change of Scenery

The rare intra-division trade! This was a blockbuster; the Orioles traded their once-franchise catcher Adley Rutschman to the Red Sox for three of their top ten prospects, a young outfielder prospect, and their everyday catcher, Carlos Narváez. Rutschman hasn't played since July 18, so the Orioles also included Jake Rogers, a veteran catcher who spent the last seven years with Detroit before a very brief stay in Baltimore.

There's a common way to assess trades like this: The team that acquired the best player is the winner. Currently, that label belongs to Rutschman, and none of the four dealt prospects have anywhere near Adley's pedigree. The former number-one-overall pick regained All-Star form in 2026; he's having his best season since 2023.

Season	PA	$wRC+$	ISO	$xWOBA$	$fWAR$
2022	470	134	.191	.341	5.6
2023	687	126	.158	.374	5.5
2024	638	103	.140	.320	2.7
2025	365	91	.146	.325	1.2
2026	284	115	.182	.349	2.3

Table 19: Rutschman's career offensive snapshot

The Red Sox have potentially added a franchise cornerstone. He's 28 years old with two years of arbitration left, so there is some pressure to ink a long-term deal, but that is certainly a good problem to have. Rutschman ranks fifth in $fWAR$ among catchers this year, despite playing less than 300 plate appearances. Since he entered the MLB, he ranks third in $fWAR$ behind Cal Raleigh and William Contreras. If Rutschman can fully recapture his early career form, the Red Sox will likely not care about the departing prospect haul.

The question is: What happened to Adley Rutschman in 2024 and 2025? What caused his dip in production?

His power took a dip, but his peripheral power numbers don't indicate a significant difference (Figure 20).

Season	Hard Hit%	<i>xSLG</i>	Barrel%	Launch Ang.
2022	30.8%	.417	7.9%	15.5
2023	29.9%	.473	7.5%	12.6
2024	28.6%	.405	6.1%	18.8
2025	35.6%	.410	7.5%	13.7
2026	35.4%	.434	7.1%	15.3

Table 20: Rutschman's power stats

There are minor differences in hard hit rate, but besides expected slugging, nothing pops out. Here are Rutschman's Baseball Savant percentiles in these categories:

Season	Avg EV	Hard Hit%	<i>xSLG</i>	Barrel%	LA Sweet Spot	Squared-Up%
2022	31	30	55	50	73	N/A
2023	32	35	77	39	78	86
2024	29	28	48	30	65	87
2025	42	29	41	36	39	~ 98
2026	52	56	66	41	96	~ 91

Table 21: Rutschman's Baseball Savant power percentiles

These stats indicate that Rutschman was never a particularly elite power threat. His exit velocity and hard-hit rate changed very little in 2022-23 versus 2024-25. His barrel rate and expected slugging percentage don't really align, either. I reframed how I was examining Rutschman's power and focused on gap power, not just home run power.

Season	HR%	XBH%	Speed Perc.	Base running Runs Above Avg.
2022	2.8%	10.4%	46	1.3
2023	2.9%	7.6%	40	-1.9
2024	3.0%	6.4%	28	-3.0
2025	2.5%	7.4%	31	-1.4
2026	2.8%	9.9%	23	-1.2

Table 22: Rutschman's gap power profile

While Rutschman's home run rate has remained steady, his overall extra base hit rate declined following his stunning rookie year, and it has risen again in 2026. Rutschman hit 35 doubles in only 470 plate appearances in 2022, but that number fell to 31 in 687 *PA* the following season. It's interesting that the Orioles chose to trade Rutschman to a division rival during what has been a resurgent offensive season individually.

In terms of swing decisions, Rutschman came into the MLB with advanced plate discipline, and that hasn't changed:

Season	K%	BB%	Whiff%	Chase%
2022	69	96	88	81
2023	90	91	94	81
2024	83	62	89	47
2025	83	80	94	88
2026	88	68	90	79

Table 23: Rutschman's plate discipline percentiles from Baseball Savant

Rutschman is having a stronger season in terms of power and he has maintained his usual level of excellence in terms of swing decisions. When he was a prospect, a huge component of his appeal was his elite defense. Rutschman looked like potentially the best all-around catcher in the MLB in 2022. Here's a look at his percentile rankings within catcher defense stats:

Season	Blocks Above Avg	CS Above Avg	Framing	2B Pop Time
2022	100	84	93	79
2023	87	50	72	81
2024	94	63	61	54
2025	61	34	76	61
2026	72	99	93	46

Table 24: Rutschman's defensive percentiles from Baseball Savant

In 2026, Rutschman ranks third in the MLB in *FRV* among catchers (9) behind Dillon Dingler (who has nearly 300 more innings) and Brandon Valenzuela (who's an unreal defensive catcher). Considering that Rutschman's *xwOBA* is now in the top 25%, this trade becomes difficult to justify from the Orioles' perspective. Rutschman is having a resurgent offensive season and has remained elite behind the dish. He is a free agent in 2028, but franchise catchers that are great on both sides of the ball certainly do not grow on trees. How are the three prospects they acquired?

Player	Age	MiLB Level	Current Season
Anthony Eyanson	21.82	AA	10 GS, 48 IP, 1.69 <i>ERA</i> , 2.61 <i>K/BB</i>
Kyson Witherspoon	21.97	A+	17 GS, 75.1 IP, 4.78 <i>ERA</i> , 2.30 <i>K/BB</i>
Eddy Azocar	19.44	A+	219 PA, .279/.338/.547, 117 <i>wRC+</i> , 0.29 <i>BB/K</i>

Table 25: Orioles' prospect return haul

Eyanson and Azocar are the most exciting prospects. Eyanson, a former 2025 third-round pick, is the 49th-ranked prospect¹. He's performed very well in Double-A despite not being 22 years old yet.

Whom	Age	ERA	FIP	WHIP	K/9	BB/9	H/9	HR/9
Anthony Eyanson	21.8	1.69	3.32	1.063	11.25	4.31	5.25	0.56
AA Eastern Lg Avg	23.7	4.71	4.71	1.409	9.74	4.23	8.46	1.19

Table 26: How Anthony Eyanson compares to the rest of AA

¹For what it's worth, Eyanson is ranked 27th on FanGraphs

There's a lot to be excited about with Eyanson. If he can improve his command, he'll be a very strong MLB pitcher. Such strong performance in AA at 21 is not to be taken lightly, and it's why Eyanson had to be included in a move for the three-time All Star catcher.

Azocar went from under the radar to an exciting prospect in just two years. He was signed out of Venezuela and at just 19, he's performed very well in High-A.

Whom	Age	Triple Slash	ISO	BB%	K%
Enddy Azocar	19.4	.279/.338/.547	.268	7.3%	25.1%
A+ South Atlantic Lg Avg	22.0	.248/.350/.417	.169	12.0%	24.6%

Table 27: How Enddy Azocar compares to the rest of A+

Azocar's power has grown substantially since his signing in 2024, as reflected by his year-to-year *ISO*:

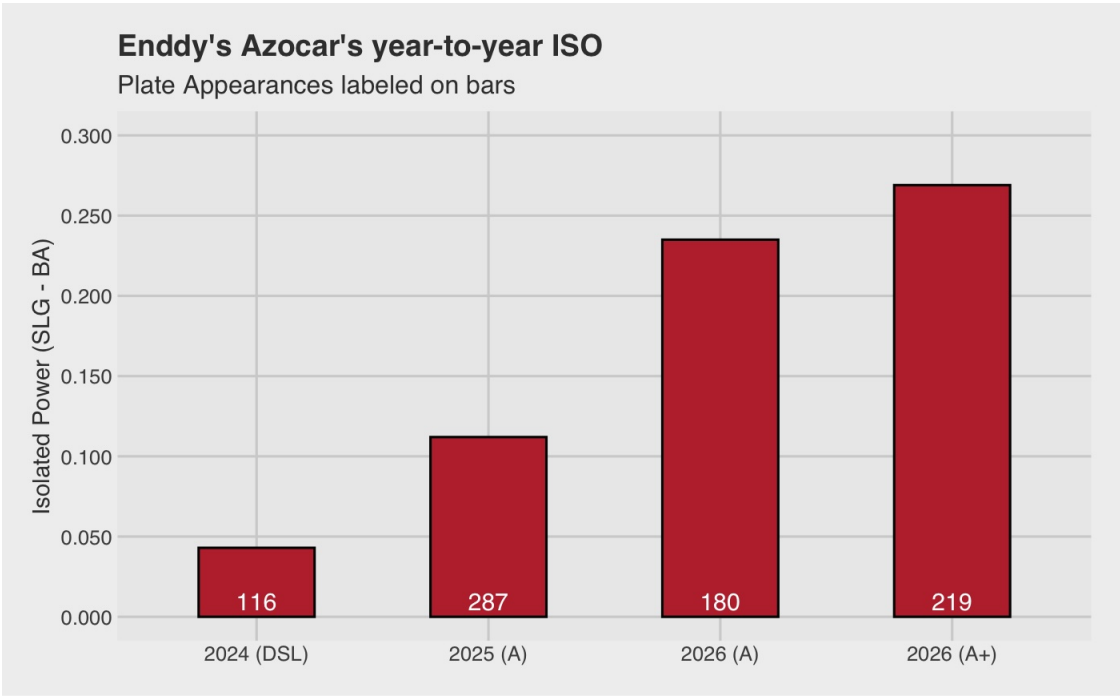


Figure 2: Enddy Azocar's Power Surge in 2026

His growth in power is exciting for another reason: Azocar is extremely fast as well. His FanGraphs speed score (8.0) ranks in the Top 15 among High-A South Atlantic players with at least 200 plate appearances.

FanGraphs is more optimistic about Azocar's potential, ranking him as the 82nd-best prospect; they believe his power surge is legit, giving him 60-grade raw power potential. It's encouraging that he's performed as well as he has at such a young age. His power wasn't accompanied by a drop in batting average, either (.279). His big area of growth will be improving the gap between his walk and strikeout rates, but at such a young age, he's been brilliant.

The third the Orioles received is Kyson Witherspoon, a 2025 first-round pick from Oklahoma. His first season in the minor leagues hasn't gone incredibly well:

Whom	Age	ERA	FIP	WHIP	K/9	BB/9	H/9	HR/9
Kyson Witherspoon	22.0	4.78	4.87	1.394	9.32	4.06	8.48	1.19
A+ South Atlantic Lg Avg	23.2	5.09	5.09	1.473	9.87	4.81	8.46	1.25

Table 28: How Kyson Witherspoon compares to the rest of A+

He's still above the league average in nearly all of the categories, but for a first-round pick with 50 FV (from MLB Pipeline), it's a little underwhelming. Witherspoon still projects to be a decent starter with a strong five-pitch mix, and given that it's his first minor league season, there's no need to panic yet.

Harold Rivas was announced as the PTBNL to complete the trade. He was signed out of Venezuela last year and he's still only 18 years old. Rivas is graded as a 40 FV prospect by both MLB Pipeline and FanGraphs, with his athleticism and defense being the most exciting parts of his profile.

Rivas has struggled offensively in the Complex League this season, but he's certainly flashing that athleticism:

Whom	Age	Triple Slash	ISO	BB%	K%	SB/SB Att
Harold Rivas	18.2	.241/.343/.429	.188	12.1%	26.3%	23/28 (82.1%)
Florida Complex Lg Avg	19.4	.251/.380/.394	.143	15.2%	23.0%	1875/2354 (79.7%)

Table 29: How Harold Rivas compares to the rest of the FCL

Rivas is flexing that strength and speed, but he's behind the curve with the bat. His walk rate looks impressive, but considering that the average walk rate in the FCL is greater than 15%, that number loses its luster. However, he's still only 18 years old, and his combination of strength, speed, and 60-grade defense could propel him through the minors of the bat picks up the slack.

The Orioles received a great prospect return. They received three players with 50 FV or higher (combining the most favorable prospect ratings from FanGraphs and MLB Pipeline), and two of them are performing like studs early on. It's great...but at the cost of their franchise cornerstone catcher?

"They have Samuel Basallo." Yes, they do, but he projects more as a 1B/DH. MLB Pipeline assessed him as a 45-grade defender and FanGraphs assessed him as a 40-grade defender. He's performed as such in the bigs:

Season	IP	DRS	Framing Runs	FRV
2025	178.2	-1	-0.9	-1
2026	382	0	-4.8	-3

Table 30: Samuel Basallo's defense at catcher in 2025-26

Among 45 catchers with 350+ innings, Basallo ranks sixth-to-last in FanGraphs' DEF² stat and third-to-last in framing runs above average. He's still not even 22, but given his potential grades, it's unlikely he becomes anything above an average defensive backstop.

Perhaps the Orioles saw their huge young core and the unlikelihood of their contending window aligning with Adley Rutschman's contract situation. Perhaps they decided

²Fielding Runs + Positional Adjustment

to embrace a younger core. Basallo’s bat has been much better this year (110 $wRC+$), but the Orioles also received a former Yankees and Red Sox catcher who is hopefully the long term solution: Carlos Narváez.

Narváez was an unheralded catcher prospect who was shipped from the Yankees to their hated rival Boston for current Top-100 propsect RHP Elmer Rodríguez. Narváez played only 15 plate appearances in 2024, but he had a very strong rookie season.

PA	Triple Slash	$wRC+$	DRS	Framing Runs	FRV	$fWAR$
446	.241/.306/.419	97	10	2.0	9	2.7

Table 31: Narváez’s 2025 Season

Narváez came out of nowhere to rank 12th in catcher $fWAR$ and eighth in FanGraphs DEF. He became one of the more well-rounded catchers in the MLB. His near-average $wRC+$ elevated him from the class of defensive specialists. However, his 2026 season has been a step back, to say the least (Figure 32).

PA	Triple Slash	$wRC+$	DRS	Framing Runs	FRV	$fWAR$
197	.187/.260/.275	47	-2	1.7	4	0.0

Table 32: Narváez’s 2026 Season

Narváez has the second-lowest $wRC+$ and the fourth-lowest $xwOBA$ among catchers in 2026. His defense is still elite (82nd percentile FRV on Baseball Savant), but his bat is channeling Jeff Mathis levels of how much patience a team can have in a bat this poor[1].

The Orioles have certainly embraced the Moneyball movie’s mantra: Rebuild in the aggregate. The bat of Samuel Basallo and the defense of Carlos Narváez recreate Adley Rutschman in the aggregate...maybe. However, it’s difficult to feel great about the trade when looking at Rutschman’s resurgent 2026 season and his continued excellence behind the plate.

In addition to Rutschman, the Red Sox acquired another catcher, Jake Rogers. Rogers spent his whole career with the Tigers prior to a very brief stay with the Orioles. He displayed a similar profile to Carlos Narváez as a defensive specialist, but recent seasons have not been kind.

Season	PA	$wRC+$	DRS	Framing Runs	FRV	$fWAR$
2019	128	28	1	-1.0	-4	-0.7
2021	127	115	1	-2.2	2	0.9
2023	365	97	0	6.5	6	2.5
2024	337	70	13	13.6	12	2.2
2025	142	70	0	1.0	0	0.3
2026	116	62	-3	-2.7	-4	-0.2

Table 33: Jake Rogers’s career two-way snapshot

In 2024, Jake Rogers was one of the best defensive catchers in the MLB. Two years later, he’s now a negative behind the dish. It’s been a baffling turn of events for Rogers, who was given a 65-grade fielding by MLB Pipeline and 80-grade by FanGraphs. Given the trade of Narváez and Rutschman’s current injury, the Red Sox needed Rogers’s inclusion. Connor Wong has looked better at catcher, but not quite average. Mickey

Gaspar has had poor early returns as an MLB catcher. The Red Sox roster Jason Delay in AAA, who has looked great behind the dish in the MLB, so he might be the emergency option if needed.

A Giant Risk

First, I understand the thought process behind the Red Sox’s decision to trade Marcelo Mayer. They are looking to compete right now, they added Caleb Durbin in the offseason, they inked Kristian Campbell to an eight-year deal, they have Franklin Arias coming up soon, and they added Curtis Mead this deadline. Those are all valid reasons to look at a struggling, uber-talented prospect with dimmed luster and try to cash out.

In a vacuum, trading for Erik Miller makes sense. Contending teams can never have too many bullpen arms. The Red Sox rank first in bullpen *FIP* and seventh in *FIP* among lefties and first in innings. However, there is always a place for a reliable reliever with a 2.76 *ERA*, even within a crowded staff. Having an extra solid arm is a good problem. Plus, Miller is cost-controlled, entering arbitration following the 2026 season.

All this is to say that I understand the motivation behind both sides of the decision. I just can’t wrap my mind around them being part of the same trade: Dealing the former 12th overall prospect with less than 400 career plate appearances for a relief pitcher who’s a luxury good. Surely there were more compelling offers for such a talented player.

That’s not to undermine Erik Miller, who has become a very good reliever. He used to have a four-pitch arsenal, but he now throws predominantly two pitches: A slider and a sinker. Both are filthy.

Season	IP	Fastball		Sinker		Slider		Changeup	
		Pct	Stuff+	Pct	Stuff+	Pct	Stuff+	Pct	Stuff+
2024	67.1	49.1%	85	0%		16.4%	134	33.8%	114
2025	30.0	34.2%	94	17.8%	132	22.2%	123	25.7%	91
2026	32.2	8.8%	100	44.9%	122	40.8%	116	5.5%	101

Table 34: Erik Miller’s Pitch Usage and Stuff+

Miller’s biggest issue is his command. He allows too many walks, which inflates his *FIP*, but he makes up for it by being elite at stranding runners, eliciting weak contact, and of course, striking batters out.

Season	K%	BB%	LOB%	Hard Hit%	SIERA
2024	84	5	19	5	70
2025	8	1	99	96	1
2026	90	7	85	100	52

Table 35: Erik Miller’s been putting it all together in 2026

In 2024, Miller struck batters out at an elite rate, but he got shelled and couldn’t strand runners. In 2025, Miller elicited weak contact and stranded runners, but he couldn’t strike batters out, and he had the worst *SIERA* in the MLB. In 2026, Miller has been elite in strikeouts, stranding runners, and hard-hit rate. He also ranks in

the top ten in groundball rate. His walk rate is once again too high, which is why his *SIERA* is mid-tier.

This year, Miller has very glaring splits.

Split	IP	ERA	K%	BB%	FIP	WHIP	GB/FB	Hard Hit%
LHH	17.1	2.08	33.8%	7.4%	2.05	1.038	3.57	12.5%
RHH	18.2	2.89	31.5%	20.2%	4.16	1.661	1.31	30.0%

Table 36: Erik Miller’s splits

There is not a huge difference in Miller’s *ERA* when facing lefties and righties, but every other stat looks like it would be terrifying to trust Miller against a right-handed bat. However, given the slight difference in *ERA* and the story of Table 35, Miller might be a case of “It’s about the destination, not the journey.” He strikes out a lot of batters, he’s become very adept at keeping runners stranded, and he doesn’t elicit a ton of hard contact. His walks will continue to give managers and fans heart palpitations, but if he can limit the actual damage, then he should be a great pickup. The Red Sox already have an elite pitching staff and bullpen, but again, there is no such thing as too many arms when gearing up for a postseason run.

There is a caveat when it comes to Miller’s groundball rate. The Red Sox have a top-ten defense, but their infield is the weak link in their defensive shape. Caleb Durbin is a stud at third, Rutschman is going to be great behind the plate, and Contreras is fine as a first baseman. Second and shortstop are questionable:

- Andrew Monasterio
 - Miscast at shortstop (-8 *OAA*, -6 *FRV* in 315 innings)
 - Okay at second and third base while with the Brewers
- Anthony Seigler
 - Okay at second (-2 *OAA*, 0 *FRV* in 308 innings)
- Trevor Story
 - He simply can not stay healthy
 - Not good at shortstop (-3 *OAA*, -2 *FRV* in 340 innings)
- Kristian Campbell
 - One of the worst defensive second basemen in 2025
 - -16 *DRS*, -8 *OAA*, -10 *FRV* in 2025
 - Does not project to be a long term option at second base defensively
- Nick Sogard
 - More of a utility guy
 - Strongest position is third base (4 career *DRS*)
 - Okay at second (-1 *DRS* in 252 career innings) and less okay at short (-3 *DRS* in 79 career innings)
- Curtis Mead
 - Covered extensively in Table 9

– Second base might be his best position

Unfortunately, Marcelo Mayer would have been their best option at second among this list defensively speaking. He struggled to hit the ball, but he played well enough at second when he was healthy (2 *OAA*, 1 *FRV* in 342 innings). He did not look great at shortstop (-2 *OAA*, -3 *FRV* in 179 innings). The Red Sox are holding out for Franklin Arias, their top prospect, who should lock down the shortstop spot on both sides of the diamond.

To turn the focus back to Mayer, this trade is unfortunate from the standpoint that it's always sad to give up on such a highly regarded prospect. The Red Sox certainly gutted their farm system, but not losing Arias was huge. The development of Arias certainly made the Red Sox front office feel better about trading Mayer. Arias was recently promoted to AAA at just 20 years old. However, if you told their front office a year ago that they would trade Mayer for a reliever in a one-for-one trade, they would have been physically ill.

How did we get here? How did Marcelo Mayer, the fourth overall pick in 2021 and the 12th-ranked prospect, get dealt for Erik Miller?

The first area of concern has nothing to do with Mayer's ability: His health. Since being drafted in 2021, Marcelo Mayer has never played 100+ games in any season.

Season	Levels	Games	Innings At		
			2B	SS	3B
2022	A, A+	91	0	694.1	0
2023	A+, AA	78	0	602.0	8.1
2024	AA	77	0	543.0	9.0
2025	AAA, MLB	77	141.0	240.0	278.2
2026 (thru. 8/3/26)	MLB	70	342.1	179.0	0

Table 37: Marcelo Mayer's games played per season

Mayer's struggles at shortstop were particularly discouraging given that he spent so much time there in the minor leagues. However, when he was healthy, Mayer played well at every minor league level.

Season	Age	Level	PA	Triple Slash	<i>wRC+</i>	<i>BB%</i>	<i>K%</i>
2021	18	CPX	107	.275/.377/.440	109	14.0%	25.2%
2022	19	A	308	.286/.406/.504	144	16.6%	25.3%
2022	19	A+	116	.265/.379/.449	124	14.7%	25.0%
2023	20	A+	164	.290/.366/.524	136	10.4%	22.6%
2023	20	AA	190	.189/.254/.355	61	7.9%	25.8%
2024	21	AA	335	.307/.370/.480	140	9.0%	19.7%
2025	22	AAA	193	.271/.347/.471	113	10.4%	19.7%

Table 38: Mayer's performance at each minor league level

It's actually very impressive how quickly Mayer would thrive at each level considering the slew of injuries he had. Many injury-plagued prospects can't find their footing, but Mayer always managed to perform very well at every minor league level. He was arguably promoted a little quickly out of AAA, but it wasn't unwarranted given his extended stay at AA and his encouraging power and walk numbers. There was likely

also an element of impatience given his injury troubles and the continuously building anticipation.

At the MLB level, his bat has not translated at all:

Season	PA	Triple Slash	<i>wRC+</i>	<i>BB%</i>	<i>K%</i>	<i>fWAR</i>
2025	136	.228/.272/.402	80	5.9%	30.1%	0.4
2026	228	.220/.282/.312	63	7.0%	19.3%	-0.1

Table 39: Mayer's brief and disappointing MLB performance

This isn't even the worst of it; Mayer's *xWOB*A in 2025 (.263) and 2026 (.263) would compete for the worst in baseball if he qualified. Mayer did many things well in the minors: He hit for average, he balanced walks and strikeouts fairly well, and he usually had an *ISO* at or near .200. In 2025, he still hit for power, but his walk-to-strikeout ratio was awful. In 2026, he's striking out far less, but his power cratered. He's not getting on base very well, so it's been a case of one step forward, three steps back.

Season	Hard Hit%	Barrel%	<i>xSLG</i>	<i>xWOB</i> A
2025	93	58	21	8
2026	27	30	2	2

Table 40: Mayer's power percentiles

Mayer has less than 400 plate appearances, so it's prudent to look his swing decisions given the larger sample size:

Season	Pitches	<i>CSW%</i>	<i>O-Swing%</i>
2025	510	20	48
2026	836	58	47

Table 41: Mayer's swing decision percentiles

Mayer's swing decision making has been okay, but he is struggling to make good contact consistently. His power was a huge part of his prospect intrigue, and it hasn't translated.

There were different outcomes to Mayer's time in Boston. There are more positive ones. One, he sticks around and eventually figures it out. Two, the Red Sox trade him, he breaks out in San Francisco, and it stings from Boston's perspective. However, given the injury troubles and the poor MLB performance, perhaps they saw the writing on the wall and decided to deal Mayer before it's too late. The goal would have been to sell high, but perhaps they did not want to be a victim of sunken cost fallacy.

There has been a lot of discourse surrounding Mayer's attitude and mentality. Much of it could be boiled down to speculation and hatchet jobs from frustrated and disappointed Bostonians. However, it is impossible to ignore the turnaround Boston has made in Mayer's absence.

Stretch	Record
With Mayer	30-40
Without Mayer	30-11
Since Mayer Got Injured	27-5

Table 42: Bad for the vibes?

This is an extremely crude exercise. Mayer’s absence does not explain the Red Sox offense remembering how to hit the baseball. However, if Mayer’s attitude concerns are real, then this phenomenon adds credence. Vibes are a very big part of baseball teams’ performance. Or this is a situation of confirmation bias.

Regardless, it’s likely that Boston was simply out of patience for Mayer. He’s extremely talented, but he needs a lot of work and the continuous injuries are preventing him from getting consistent reps. The Red Sox are hoping Kristian Campbell pans out, waiting for Franklin Arias to take over shortstop, and they recently traded for Caleb Durbin and Curtis Mead. They are going a different direction with their infield.

A New Pair of Wheels

This trade is straight-forward. Every MLB contender needs situational guys; players who shine in very specific moments. One of those moments is being the tying or winning baserunner in a late-game situation. Every playoff team needs a pair of wheels on the bench. That’s what the Red Sox are getting in Eli White:

Player	Speed Score
Corbin Carroll	8.6
Jorge Mateo	8.4
Johan Rojas	8.4
Elly De La Cruz	8.3
Sam Haggerty	8.1
Eli White	8.0

Table 43: The fastest MLB players since 2023

White has ranked in the top five percent in sprint speed since he’s been in the MLB. On top of his world class speed, White is also a good defender in the outfield. The Red Sox already have a tremendous outfield defensive trio in Duran-Rafaela-Abreu, but White is not here to take any of their spots. He’s here to pinch run and it’s a bonus that the Red Sox defense doesn’t lose a step when he’s on the field.

White’s bat isn’t a plus (84 *wRC+* last year), but he has some pop. White had a .172 *ISO* in 2025, an above-average mark. The Red Sox made a sneaky transaction in acquiring White.

The Braves received Tyler Uberstine in return. He’s a 27-year-old rookie relief pitcher who gave Boston mixed results in his first taste of MLB action (2.2 IP, 3 H, 1 BB, 1 ER, 2 K). Uberstine has pitched well in AAA this year (32 IP, 2.81 *ERA*, 3.35 *FIP*, 1.000 *WHIP*) and he should be a solid relief arm in Atlanta. However, we’ve already discussed how Boston has elite pitching. Boston is the eighth-fastest team by Speed Score, but White’s speed makes him a very valuable addition, and I have no doubt we’ll see him called upon to fly around the bases in the playoffs.

Concluding Remarks

Boston was extremely aggressive at the trade deadline. Their window slammed open with their torrid play in July, and they capitalized on their newfound dominance. They needed a reliable bat in the infield, so they acquired Curtis Mead. They desperately needed a good catcher and they acquired an elite catcher in Adley Rutschman. They needed specialists, so they acquired the lefty killer Jahmai Jones, the sprinter Eli White, and another lefty killer Erik Miller.

They lost a lot of prospect capital, but they should be able to fill the gaps left by those players. Marcelo Mayer's place will be taken by Mead, Kristian Campbell, and Franklin Arias. They lost a few pitching prospects, but they have an exciting young staff led by Payton Tolle and Jake Bennett. Ranger Suarez is under contract for the rest of the decade. Garrett Crochet will hopefully be back soon. They traded a surging prospect in Endy Azocar, but they already have the aforementioned trio of Duran, Rafaela, and Abreu with Roman Anthony on the mend. They traded a lot of young talent, but those prospects' potential roles are currently occupied by developed young talent.

Contending windows are very fickle in the MLB. They can open quickly and close just as violently, and they shouldn't be taken for granted. The Red Sox are taking this window as seriously as a team can and opting for guarantees rather than potential.

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